

Session 25: Unity Not Uniformity (Eph. 4:1-16)

Key Takeaways

- The concept of the fullness or completeness of the number seven is seen all over the Hebrew Bible, especially on page 1 in Genesis.
- In Ephesians 4:7, Paul develops the point that unity is not uniformity.
- Paul quotes from Psalm 68 in Ephesians 4, and it's clear that this psalm influences the whole letter.

The Unity of God's Family: Translation and Literary Design of Ephesians 4:1-16

¹ Therefore I urge y'all,
I the prisoner in the Lord,
to walk
in a manner worthy of the calling
with which y'all have been called,
² with all humility and gentleness,
with patience,
bearing with one another in love,
³ being zealous to keep the one-ness of the Spirit
with the bond of peace:
⁴ **one** body and **one** Spirit,
just as y'all were called by **one** hope of y'all's calling,
⁵ **one** Lord, **one** faith, **one** baptism,
⁶ **one** God and Father
of everyone,
who is over all and through all and in all.

⁷ But to each one of us was given grace/gift
according to the measure of the gift of the Messiah.

⁸ Therefore it says:
"Having ascended to the height,
he took captive the captive forces;
he gave gifts to people."

⁹ Now, what is "he ascended,"
except that he also descended to the lower regions of the land?

¹⁰ The one who descended,
he is also the one who ascended
high above all things in the heavenly realms,
in order that he might fulfill all things.

¹¹ And he gave some on the one hand as apostles,
and some prophets,
and some evangelists,
and some as shepherds and teachers,
¹² for the equipping of the holy ones
for the work of the ministry,
for the building of the body of the Messiah,
¹³ until we all attain
unto the unity of the faith
and unto the knowing of the Son of God,
unto a mature man,
unto the measure of the stature of the fullness of the Messiah,
¹⁴ so that we might no longer be babies,
tossed by waves
and driven by every wind of teaching
done by the trickery of humans,
in the craftiness
of a scheme of deception,
¹⁵ but doing truth in love,
let us grow up in everything into **him**,
who is the head,
Messiah
¹⁶ from whom all the body,
being joined together
and being united together
through every supporting joint,
according to the working by the measure of each one of the parts,
produces the growth of the body
for the building up of itself in love.

Ephesians 4:1-16. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

Flow of Thought in 4:1-16

Ephesians 4:1-6

Ephesians 4:1: Paul picks up the thread from Ephesians 2:10 that people of God's new creation have a whole new way of life opened up to them, "good works" to "walk" in. Paul now begins the move toward summoning these church communities to live out these works in their walk.

Ephesians 4:2-3: Paul highlights that this new way of unified life will require enormous personal growth, relational maturity, and conflict resolution skills. But it's the only reasonable response, given the cosmic unity of God and his people.

Ephesians 4:4-6: This is a poetic summary of chapters 1-3 through the lens of the messianic Shema. Notice how the list builds in a Trinitarian climax, beginning with the Spirit (who creates the body to live by hope), to the Messiah (and believing loyalty and identification with him in baptism), and then to God the Father (who transcends and is in all creation).

The seven unities of Ephesians 4:4-6:

1. One body: The community of Jesus' followers that constitutes the present incarnation of Jesus (Eph. 1:23; 3:6; 4:12, 16; 5:23, 30)
2. One Spirit: The personal presence of the Father and Jesus that energizes the church (Eph. 1:20; 3:16, 20)
3. One hope: The future redemption and inheritance of the new creation promised in the Messiah (Eph. 1:11-14, 18; 3:6)
4. One Lord: The risen Jesus exalted to cosmic rule as Lord of all nations (Eph. 1:20-23, 3:10-11)
5. One faith: The open secret of the good news of the crucified and risen Messiah (Eph. 1:13; 4:11-13, 21)
6. One baptism: The means of incorporation into the resurrection and new creation (Eph. 2:1-11)
7. One God and Father of all: The one God and Father of the new messianic family (Eph. 1:2-3, 17; 2:18; 3:14; 5:20; 6:23)

Ephesians 4:7-10

Ephesians 4:7-8: Having emphasized the unity of the Messiah's people, Paul quickly develops the point that unity is not uniformity. The Messiah has "given grace-gifts" to his people as a divine victor, which leads his mind to Psalm 68.

Ephesians 4:9-10: Paul identifies the divine victor Yahweh of Psalm 68 with the crucified Jesus, whose ascension was preceded by his descent to the grave (Paul is placing the victory motif of Psalm 68 within the foundational Messiah narrative of descent/ascent that he expresses elsewhere in his letters, Phil. 2, 2 Cor. 8:10). The victor is precisely the crucified one.

Ephesians 4:11-16

Ephesians 4:11-12: The "gifts" are leaders whose abilities sustain and guide the unity of God's people. They "build up" (a temple metaphor) God's people so they can do the "work" (recalling 2:10) of service.

- Ephesians 4:13: The goal is that the unified people of the Messiah embody the new humanity (a mature/complete human) that resembles the "fullness of the Messiah." No one person can fully reflect

the truly human Messiah, but a unified group of his followers can.

- Ephesians 4:14: A mature messianic humanity won't be susceptible to cultural pressures or deceptive teachers.
- Ephesians 4:15-16: People who are "doing truth" (lit. "truthing," ἀληθευοντες) in love are able to grow like a complex but organized body that attaches to the head, who is the Messiah.

Key Interpretive Issues in 4:1-16

The quotation of Psalm 68 in Ephesians 4:7-10:

Ephesians 4:7-10 Instructor's Translation

⁷ But to each one of us was given grace/gift according to the measure of the gift of the Messiah. ⁸

Therefore it says:

Having ascended to the height,
he took captive the captives;
he gave gifts to people."

⁹ Now, "he ascended," what is this, except that he also descended to the lower regions of the land? ¹⁰ The one who descended, he is also the one who ascended high above all things in the heavenly realms, in order that he might fulfill all things.

In the Hebrew and Greek version of Psalm 68, the text clearly reads "received" not "gave."

Ephesians 4:8	Psalm 68:18 Hebrew Text	Psalm 67:18 Septuagint
Having ascended to the height, he took captive the captives; he gave gifts to people."	You ascended to the height You took captive the captives you received gifts among men	You ascended to the height You took captive the captives you received gifts among men
ἀναβὰς εἰς ὕψος ἡχμαλώτευσεν αἰχμαλωσίαν, ἔδωκεν δόματα τοῖς ἀνθρώποις.	עלית למרום שבית שבי מתנות באדם לקחת	ἀνέβης εἰς ὕψος, ἡχμαλώτευσας αἰχμαλωσίαν, ἔλαβες δόματα ἐν ἀνθρώπῳ,
Ephesians 4 and Two Translations of Psalm 68. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).		

However, Paul is not just quoting this line of Psalm 68 out of context. He has the narrative arc of the entire poem in mind, and he has adapted the wording of the quoted line in the light of the concluding line of the poem.

Psalm 68:32-35 Hebrew Text (Instructor's Translation)

³² Kings of the land, sing to God, praise the Lord. ³³ To him who rides upon the highest heavens, which are from ancient times; behold, he gives with his voice, a mighty voice. ³⁴ Give strength to God; his majesty is

over Israel and his strength is in the skies. ³⁵ O God, awesome from your sanctuary. The **God of Israel himself gives strength and power** to the people.

Psalm 68:33-36 Septuagint/LXX

³³ Kings of the land, sing to God, praise the Lord. Sing to the God ³⁴ who rides on the heaven of the heavens toward the east. Behold he gives his voice, a voice of power. ³⁵ Give glory to God, over Israel is his majesty and his power is in the clouds. ³⁶ O God, awesome among your holy ones, the **God of Israel will give power and might** to his people.

Paul is alluding to the entirety of Psalm 68. From the divine warrior's battle with his enemies (Ps. 68:1-2), he leads the enslaved poor into liberation and freedom as their true Father (Ps. 68:3-6). This liberation is explicitly connected to the Exodus and wilderness migration (Ps. 68:7-14). And then, after the victory over Egypt, the divine warrior arrives at Mount Sinai (Ps. 68:15-19). Yahweh's choice of Mount Sinai is portrayed as staking a claim over against Mount Bashan in the north of Canaan, which was associated with the powers of spiritual evil (Ps. 68:15). Yahweh's enemies are called "the wild animal in the reeds" (Ps. 68:30a) that Yahweh must rebuke and the "bulls with the calves of the people, trampling underfoot" (Ps. 68:30b). The forces of spiritual evil are typically portrayed as wild animals (Dan. 7), so Paul's attention was naturally drawn to this poem in describing the Messiah's victory and processional enthronement over the powers of darkness (Eph. 1:20-21). It also seems like Paul's many prayers that God supply strength and power to his people are adapting the language of the final line of this victory poem (Ps. 68:32-35): God ascends the holy mountain to take up residence in his temple, so that he can give strength and power to his people. It is this entire set of concepts that Paul is drawing upon in his adaptation.

This is similar to how Paul quotes from Isaiah 59:20 in Romans 11:26 but adapts the words based on other scriptural texts that focus on the same theme.

Isaiah 59:20:

- Hebrew text: "A redeemer will come to Zion (לציון)."
• Greek Septuagint: "A redeemer will come on account of Zion (ἐνεκαυ Σιων)."
• Paul in Romans 11:26: "A redeemer will come from Zion (ἐκ Σιων)."

Paul is reading Isaiah 59:20 in light of a few other Zion-restoration texts that say God's messianic salvation will emerge from Zion and go out to the nations.

- Psalm 14:7 and 53:6: "O that salvation for Israel would come from Zion (מציון = ἐκ Σιων) when Yahweh restores his people."
• Psalm 110:2: "Yahweh will send your scepter of strength from Zion (מציון = ἐκ Σιων)."

Ephesians 4:8: "He gave gifts to people," whereas Psalm 68:18 (LXX 67:18) reads "he received gifts from people."

"The author's use of ἐδωκεν in Ephesians 4:8 is not a 'reversal' of meaning. The author is doing more than citing merely one verse within the psalm in order to provide his scriptural warrant; rather, he is looking to the movement of the psalm as a whole. The imagery of divine warfare in this context indicates that the ideology of divine warfare ... provides the key to understanding the author's aim in appropriating Psalm 68 to speak of the giving of χάρις to the church. He depicts Christ as the triumphant Divine Warrior who, after

he has ascended his throne, blesses his people with gifts ... Psalm 68, which is quoted in Ephesians 4:8, celebrates Yahweh as the conquering Divine Warrior, and utilizes the pattern of divine warfare to portray him as such. Significantly for our purposes, it contains this element of blessing after victory and enthronement, as it depicts Yahweh conquering his enemies and then blessing his people with gifts ... In our view, the imagery of Yahweh ascending to his heavenly throne from which he blesses his people is what the author aims to capture in the quotation in Ephesians 4:8 ... In this manner, the author portrays Christ as the victorious Divine Warrior who has the right to give gifts to his people because of his triumphs.”

Gombis, Timothy G. (2005). “Cosmic Lordship and Divine Gift-Giving: Psalm 68 in Ephesians 4:8.” *Novum Testamentum*. Brill. 373-375.

“The lower parts of the earth” (4:9)

There are two main options in the interpretive tradition:

1. The “lower regions” is from the reference point of the heavens, and so refers to the land itself. On this reading, the sentence refers to the incarnation, the (unmentioned) death, and then the exaltation.
2. The “lower regions” is from the reference point of the land, meaning under the land, that is, the grave. This is common biblical imagery for the grave. Paul is contrasting here the exaltation of the triumphant risen Messiah with his preceding humiliation, death, and burial “in the earth.” This view does not necessitate the “harrowing of hell” tradition that developed much later. Rather, this is a reference to Jesus’ death that brought about his victory over the forces of spiritual evil, referred to in Psalm 68 as “the captives.”

“We simply want to establish the point that the phrase in v. 9 points to the grave as the place to which Christ descended, and that this reference has in view the death of Christ. This finds confirmation from Ephesians 2:13-16, where the author writes of the death of Christ as the means whereby he triumphed over the powers. He states that the basic division within humanity—the division between Jews and Gentiles—has been overcome ‘by the blood of Christ’ (ἐν τῷ αἵματι τοῦ Χριστοῦ). Further, these two groups are part of the one body of Christ ‘through the cross’ (διὰ τοῦ σταυροῦ), and it is by the cross that Christ has put to death the enmity that existed between them. By his death Christ has triumphed over the divisive effects of the enemy powers who have so ordered this present evil age as to create and exacerbate divisions within humanity.”

Gombis, Timothy G. (2005). “Cosmic Lordship and Divine Gift-Giving: Psalm 68 in Ephesians 4:8.” *Novum Testamentum*. Brill. 376-377.

Reflection Question

Paul is emphasizing the theme of unity in Ephesians 4:1-16. How do you know that he’s not also emphasizing uniformity or sameness?